



THE YANOMAMI PEOPLE OF THE AMAZON BASIN

are one of the largest and most remote rainforest groups in South America, where they have lived for 50,000 years. Their way of life consists of hunting and fishing,

YANOMAMI

CARETAKERS OF THE RAINFOREST

Ancient world

The large Yanomami population (there are thought to be over 20,000) live in hundreds of villages scattered through the dense rain forest near the Brazil/Venezuela border. The greatest number live deep inside the forest, while some have settled along the banks of major rivers, including the Negro and the Orinoco.



COMMUNITY LIFE

Between 40 and 300 people live in each Yanomami village; the journey between villages can take anything from a few minutes to several days. Neighboring settlements are independent, yet they keep in constant touch.

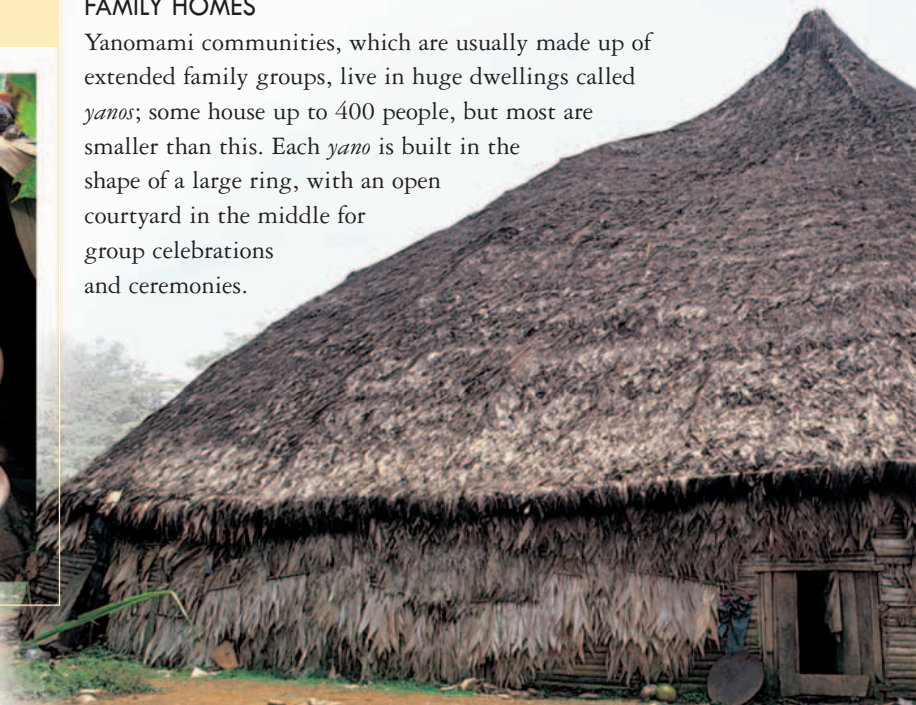
MAGIC LIQUID

To make beer from *manioc* (also called sweet cassava), the creamy white root is first mashed, then chewed by village women until it is mixed with their saliva. At this stage, all the women spit it into one large jar where, after a few days, it begins to ferment. Eventually, it turns into a potent drink that is highly valued for both social and ceremonial purposes. This boy hopes his bowl of beer will ward off evil spirits.



FAMILY HOMES

Yanomami communities, which are usually made up of extended family groups, live in huge dwellings called *yanos*; some house up to 400 people, but most are smaller than this. Each *yano* is built in the shape of a large ring, with an open courtyard in the middle for group celebrations and ceremonies.



FOOD AND DRINK

This girl carries a bundle of fruit from the spiny palm tree on her back. The Yanomami diet consists mostly of vegetables and fruit, which the women gather from the forest. These are usually supplemented by meat of some kind, but this is becoming increasingly scarce, since large areas of forest have been destroyed, and with them the habitat of many birds and animals.



HOME COMFORTS

Inside the *yano*, each family has its own area, which is centered around an open fire. Most people sleep in hammocks hung in layers from the ceiling, but some younger Yanomami sleep under the stars.